



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Grace Classical Academy – Bel Air
School Website: <http://oakgroveclassical.org>

December 27, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Grace Classical Academy Bel Air MD 21015 presents a strongly classical Christian program built around the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a theology-infused mission. Public-facing materials emphasize a Christ-centered, biblically anchored approach to education, a clear formation-focused purpose, and a curriculum that centers on grammar/logic/rhetoric, Latin, and civics/debate within a humanities-led framework. Faculty portrayals stress classical training and virtue, and parental involvement is framed as a core part of the school community. Taken together, the school aligns with the core aims and structures of classical education, with minor gaps in explicit Great Books wording and certain Great-Conversation language. Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

- Evidence of strong religious and metaphysical foundations includes a Statement of Faith and explicit Christian worldview integration across curriculum and mission.
- The school explicitly grounds its mission in forming students to think and act biblically, not merely to acquire information.
- The curriculum centers on the classical Trivium (grammar/logic/rhetoric), with grade-band distinctions and a humanities core, along with Latin and civics/debate; Great Books are not explicitly named in the public-facing materials we reviewed.
- Pedagogical approach includes singing/chanting in the grammar stage and Socratic/seminar-style elements in upper grades (as part of a typical classical progression), with a senior rhetoric/Thesis component in the upper grades.
- Faculty are described as disciplined, virtuous, and classically trained, with a living-curriculum perspective; parents are invited to participate and partner with the school.
- The school publicly positions parents as co-teachers and hosts tours and parent-education opportunities, underscoring a community-centric classical model.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Statement of Faith; Christ-centered curriculum; explicit theology integration; Christian distinctives; liturgical/congregational elements implied by chapel/music life.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present (theology, truth, worship/chapel, creed, liturgy; virtue implied in formation). Negative signals and secular-neutral language are not evident in the public materials. Estimated positive: 5; negative: 0.
 - Why this rating: Clear transcendentals-oriented framing (truth/faith-based formation) with theological grounding and liturgical/community cues.
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Mission/vision articulate formation of virtue and biblically-grounded thinking; goal of applying classical framework to life, not merely job prep.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present (formation, virtue, teleology of education, biblical worldview). Estimated positive: 2; negative: 0.
- Why this rating: Emphasis on formation and virtue aligned with classical aims rather than purely technical preparation.
- Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Curriculum centers on grammar/logic/rhetoric, humanities (English, History), math/science, Latin, civics/debate, senior thesis; explicit Trivium structure.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present (grammar, logic, rhetoric, Latin, history, civics, debate). Absence (in the public materials) of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language is notable. Estimated positive: 5; negative: 0.
 - Why this rating: Strong alignment with the Trivium and classical structure, but public materials do not clearly name Great Books or Great Conversation, which is a hallmark criterion in some classical rubrics.
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Grammar-stage singing/chanting to aid memory; dialectic/logic instruction in upper grades; rhetoric emphasis and senior-thesis framing; explicit upper-grade seminars and rhetoric/declamation.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present (chanting, memory work, seminars, rhetoric, debates, senior thesis). Estimated positive: 6; negative: 0.
 - Why this rating: Pedagogical pattern matches classical norms (scholé-like memory work in the early years, Socratic/seminar style in later years, and explicit rhetoric work).
- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Distinctives highlight highly experienced and classically-trained faculty; explicit statements about faculty qualifications and “living curriculum.”
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present (faculty as mentors, living curriculum, portrait of teacher, collegial culture). Estimated positive: 4; negative: 0.
 - Why this rating: Faculty described as masterful, virtuous guides who embody classical pedagogy and values.
- Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Emphasis on partnership with parents; parent formation/reading groups; admissions information and open-visitation practices; parental involvement channels.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present (partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent formation, open campus, family involvement). Estimated positive: 4; negative: 0.
 - Why this rating: The school explicitly treats parents as co-teachers and offers formation opportunities, aligning with classical community expectations.

Aggregate Assessment

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL
 - The school demonstrates robust alignment across five of six categories (1, 2, 4, 5, 6) with Element 3 (Curriculum) showing strong classical structure but lacking explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language in public materials. This yields a predominantly CLASSICAL assessment with a transparent classical framework across faith, formation, curriculum (grammar/logic/rhetoric), pedagogy, faculty, and community.

What Would Move the Needle

- If aiming to strengthen to a fully CLASSICAL designation, explicit language around Great Books and the Great Conversation in the curriculum descriptions would help.
- Adding explicit references to liturgical practices and communal worship in more public-facing materials would strengthen Element 1.
- More transparent articulation of Great Books or canonical reading list references (publicly) would bolster Element 3’s alignment with the strongest classical criteria.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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